unremitting ‘class struggle’ that he launched later, culminating in the catastrophic Cultural Revolution. Mao argued that a large number of Party members were from the ranks of the petty bourgeoisie and that they could subvert the ideological purity of Marxism–Leninism and Mao Zedong Thought. They had to be constantly subjected to criticism, self-criticism and re-education, and even purged from the Party if they constituted a threat to its authority. This became a convenient way of attacking and neutralizing rivals in the Party, and Mao proved to be most adept in using it to strengthen his position as the supreme leader. The use of self-criticism and ideological re-education became a means for the Party and its leader to establish psychological dominance over rivals and dissenters. It continues to be a key instrument for asserting Party authority and enforcing ideological conformity.

The 1945 Resolution is extraordinarily detailed and describes the various stages of the power struggle within the Party and the dramatis personae involved. It establishes the position of Mao as the top leader and chief ideologue of the revolution, and details the organizational principles and methods through which the Party would function as the vanguard of the revolution. While emphasizing the importance of the principle of ‘democratic centralism’, the document has no reference to the concept of collective leadership. There is no warning against the personality cult. These concepts begin to appear in Party documents only in the 1950s. The Resolution was adopted at a time when the War of Resistance against Japan was still raging but in its final stages. The civil war was about to intensify. The document reflects the confidence that the CPC would inherit the mandate to rule over All Under Heaven, or Tianxia.

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The second Resolution, adopted on 27 June 1981, is also historic, and for a Party document unusually candid. Entitled Resolution on Certain Questions in the History of Our Party Since the Founding of the PRC, it is a comprehensive assessment of the role of Mao Zedong as China’s leader. It praises his contributions during the phase of building up of the CPC,